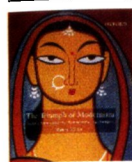


THE COLONIAL CANVAS

This lavishly illustrated volume is a guide through the labyrinths of the Indian art scene during the Raj



**THE TRIUMPH OF MODERNISM:
INDIA'S ARTISTS AND THE
AVANT-GARDE, 1922-1947**
by PARTHA MITTER
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■ By Geeta Doctor

If Partha Mitter's earlier book derived its title from the sacred monsters of Indian art, this one should be called 'Delectable Delights'. In his lavishly illustrated volume, the tender gaze of the artists inspired by the Bengal Movement captures the lineaments of Santhal girls returning from their morning dip in the pristine village ponds and misty river banks with all the erotic romanticism that we now associate with a song and dance sequence in a modern-day film.

Let us quickly add that these are not Mitter's intentions at all. He is Emeritus Professor of Art History at the University of Sussex, and an academic who has devoted his life to tracing the convoluted interactions in the jargon favoured by those for whom there is never a dialogue between two opposing groups that is not a discourse. In short, he takes us back, like the practised guide he is, to the labyrinth of misunderstandings and false turnings, artistic dead ends and sudden awakenings, to new dawns that mark the landscape of colonial encounters.

It plays like a board game. Those who are familiar with the main players—Rabindranath Tagore and his enormously talented family members; the acolytes Nandalal Bose, Benodebehari Mukhopadhyaya and Ramkinkar Baij; the men who could have been kings but who broke away,

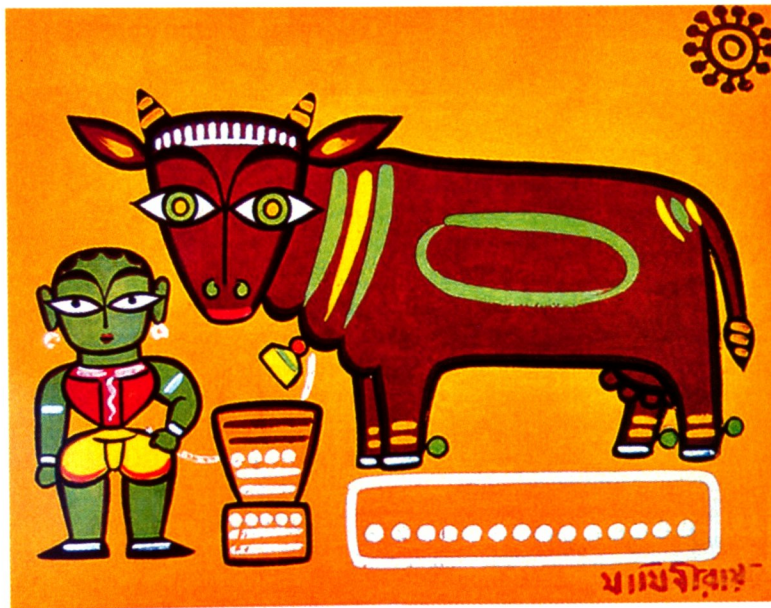
like Jamini Roy and Debiprosad Roy Chowdhury, to name just a few of those who made up the Bengal team, as against "pleine air" and "drawing from the nude", Royal Academy ruffians who dominated the Bombay art scene; and the Queen of Indian modernists, Amrita Sher-Gil—will just fall upon it with undiluted glee. Mitter is superb in the latter part of the book, where he recreates the Byzantine politics involved in securing the commission to decorate the walls of the most prestigious of architectural undertakings, the Baker-Lutyens plan for the new imperial Capital at Delhi,

BEST OF BENGAL: Much of the book is devoted to artists like Jamini Roy

mention Bombay again, N.S. Bendre, K.K. Hebbar and P.T. Reddy. Baroda gets a look-in mostly on account of the commission received by Bose to create murals for the Maharaja, and Mysore because it nurtured K. Venkatappa, who was fortunate enough to be drawn into the circle of Abanindranath Tagore. Andhra artist Damerla Rama Rao finds a mention though he studied at the J.J. School of Art in Mumbai, under Gladstone Solomon, the principal, who is one of the betes noires of the study. Charles Gerrard, who was principal between 1936 and 1946, might have ushered in the era of Impressionists and Post-Impressionists at the school and inspired his

students, but he's not given much space in the book.

Do we see a pattern emerging? Are artists equal here in this 'animal farm', but some more equal than the others? If we can ignore this bias, some of the best sections of the book are those devoted to artists such as Jamini Roy and Deviprosad Roy Chowdhry. They are described as handsome men with wonderful heads. By placing them in the context of the nation-



now the Presidential Complex and the Secretariat, as also the India House, the Dome in London and the artistic fall-out of such rivalries.

Others will wonder about those who don't have a role to play on either of the home teams, those who were in such distant corners of the Empire as Lahore, Lucknow and Indore in the years of the study (1922-1947). They must have tried out their own skills on the anvil of modernism, as in the case of artists such as B.C. Sanyal, Dhanraj Bhagat, the Sri Lankan George Keyt, or if we have to be tedious and

alist movement even while under the pressure of Raj patronage, Mitter underlines their heroic stature. Strangely, he rarely gives much importance to the art of South-East Asia, which in fact influenced the likes of Tagore and Rukmini Devi, the dancer who created a unique centre for the arts at Kalakshetra in south India. Perhaps, in signalling the potent power exerted by the West on the emerging art of India, he believes that the only valuable discourse, to use his favourite word, is the one that can be undertaken with the West. ■